



◀ CANADIAN TROOPS GO “OVER THE TOP”

The moment of climbing out of the frontline trench to advance on the enemy – known as going “over the top” – was dreaded by every infantryman. Junior officers traditionally led the way into no-man’s-land, themselves unarmed or carrying only a pistol.

KEY EVENTS

1914–18

■ **November 1914** After an initial phase of mobile warfare, the armies on the Western Front settle into entrenched positions.

■ **April 1915** The Germans make the first effective use of poison gas, releasing chlorine from cylinders against unprotected French colonial and Canadian troops at the Second Battle of Ypres.

■ **July 1916** On the first day of the Somme offensive, British troops suffer more than 57,000 casualties, including 19,000 killed.

■ **June 1917** At Messines, 19 mines explode simultaneously in tunnels dug under German lines, killing 10,000 and allowing a British advance.

■ **November 1917** Massed British tanks help infantry achieve a breakthrough at Cambrai, although the opportunity is not exploited.

■ **March 1918** German forces, spearheaded by Stormtroopers, achieve a major breakthrough in the Michael offensive. Mobility returns to the war, which ends in the defeat of Germany, in November.

◀ A GERMAN GAS MASK

Developed during the war in response to chemical attacks, gas masks had goggles to protect the eyes and a chemical breathing filter that neutralized harmful substances. Poison gases used in the war included chlorine, phosgene, and mustard gas.



gas claimed many thousands of lives and contributed to the general misery of trench life, but it had no decisive effect.

The British placed great faith in tanks. These slow-moving armoured vehicles advanced in front of the infantry in many offensives from 1916 onwards. However, their effectiveness was

limited by their tendency to break down and, in spite of their heavy armour, their vulnerability to artillery fire.

In the end, trench warfare was transformed by a gradual evolution of artillery and infantry tactics, integrating new technology in effective ways. Aerial observation from aircraft and tethered balloons, linked to the ground by radio, improved the targetting of big guns. Flash-spotting and sound-ranging techniques allowed gunners to pinpoint and destroy enemy batteries, based on the sight and sound of their gunfire. The tight coordination of artillery and infantry was crucial to the “rolling barrage” – a curtain of supporting shellfire advancing only 50m (165ft) ahead of the soldiers. Light machine-guns, grenades, portable mortars, and flame-throwers improved the armament of attacking troops, while German elite Stormtroopers used shock assault tactics to punch holes in enemy defences. In 1918, Germany’s assault on Allied trenches – and its eventual failure – signalled the end of trench warfare in World War I.



“[The regiment’s] assault failed of success because **dead men** can advance no further”

GENERAL BEAUVOIR DE LYLE, ON THE NEWFOUNDLAND REGIMENT, 1 JULY 1916